



One content platform on GCP

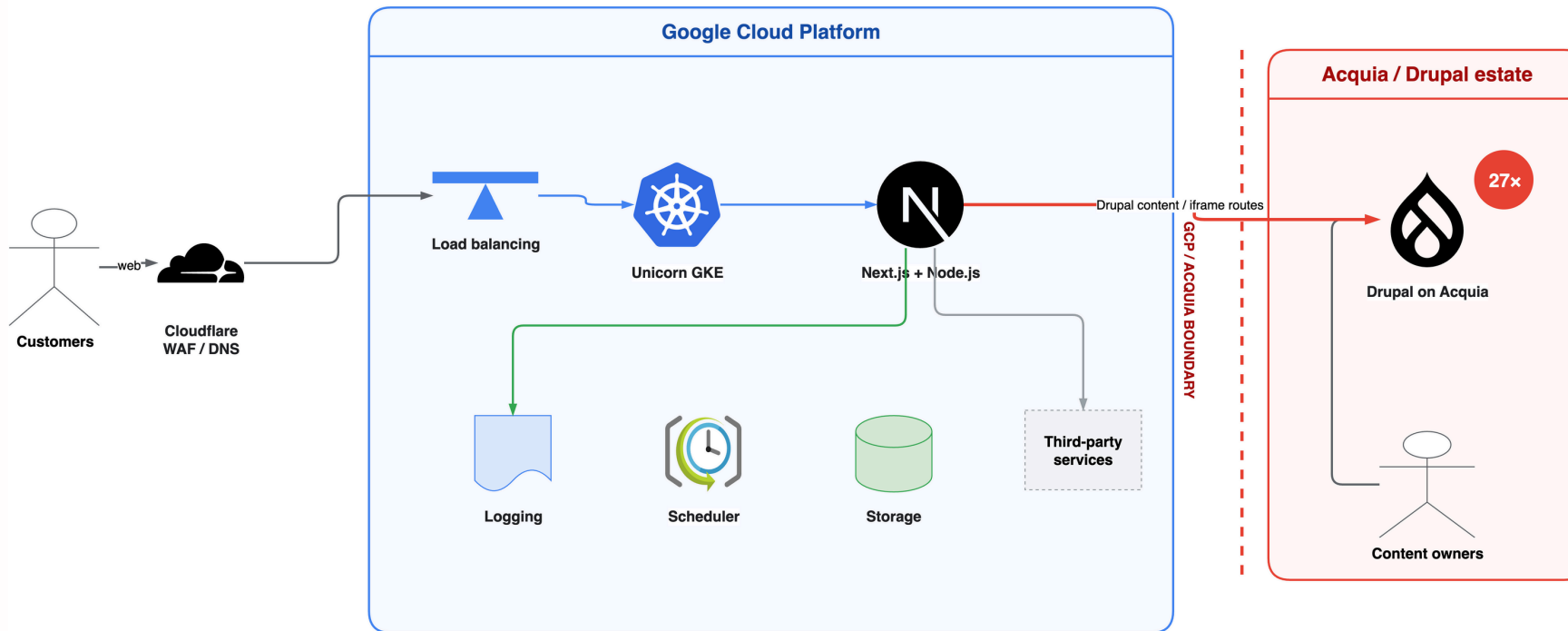
Why the 27-site Drupal estate no longer scales—and how we choose a successor

CURRENT ARCHITECTURE

Today Next.js already mixes native and Drupal delivery across the GCP / Acquia boundary

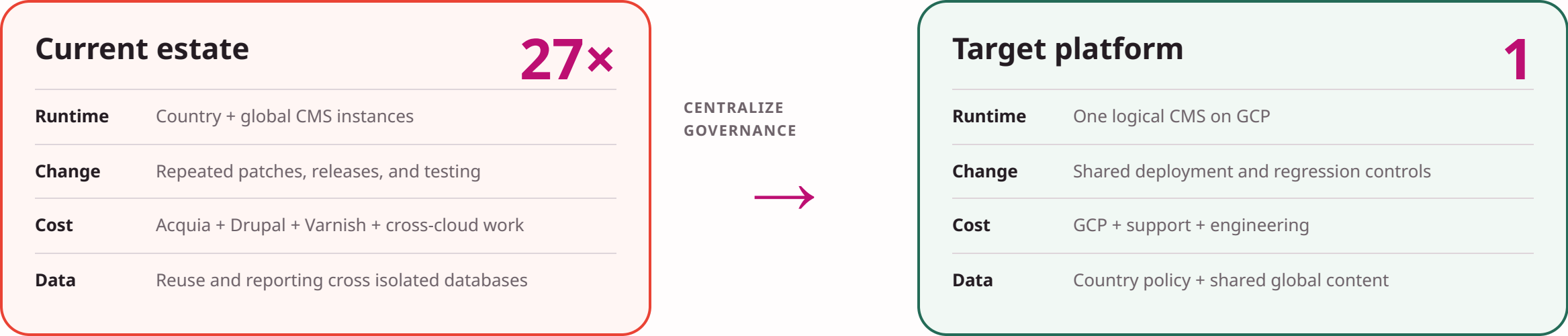
Current platform context: Next.js composes GCP and Drupal delivery

CMS delivery only: native Next.js routes and legacy Drupal / iframe routes cross the GCP / Acquia boundary directly.



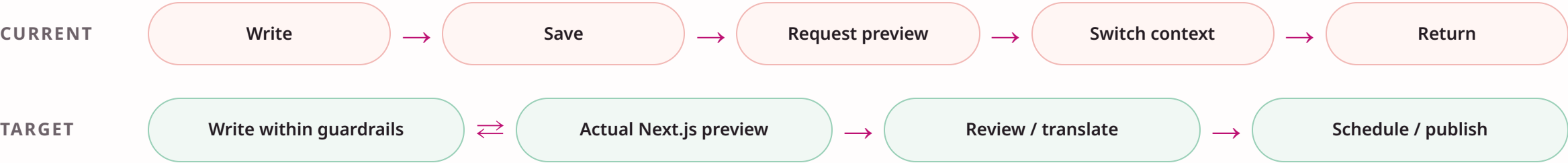
Mixed delivery exists today; migration can move route ownership gradually instead of waiting for one big cutover.

Twenty-seven duplicated stacks versus one governed platform



The savings hypothesis is reduced duplication—not a claim that the replacement CMS is free.

Today preview interrupts writing; the target keeps preview continuous



Continuous preview

No separate low-confidence preview action

Role-shaped flow

Review, translation, approval, schedule

Governed creation

Approved blocks, forms, and human-reviewed Enterprise AI

Content-manager usability is a PoC gate. Engineering fit cannot compensate for poor daily authoring.

ENGINEERING DIFFERENCE

Today CMS customization is a separate PHP stack; the target reuses TypeScript

CURRENT CUSTOMIZATION

Drupal + PHP modules

separate types · UI · tests · telemetry

Acquia operations

VERSUS

TARGET CUSTOMIZATION

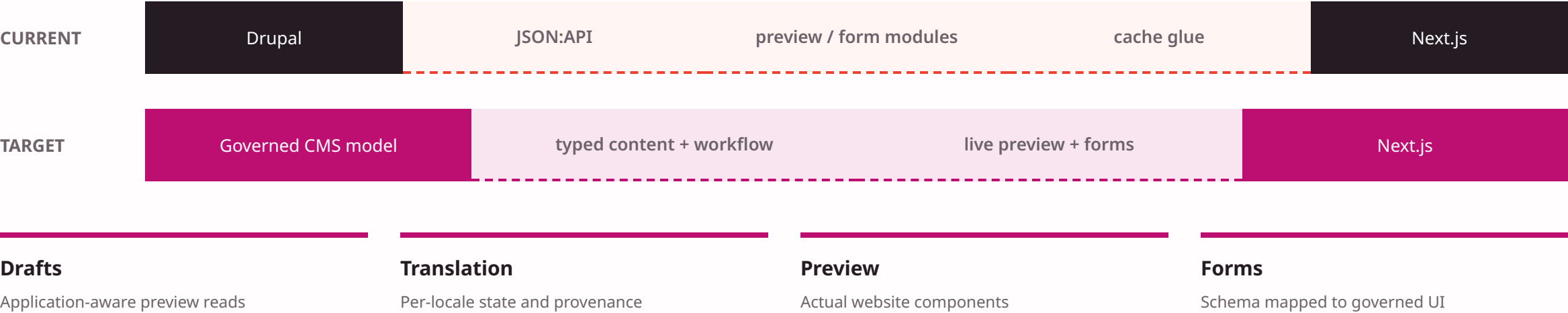
CMS schema + hooks + jobs

React Admin + shared design system

TypeScript tests + GCP telemetry

PHP is not the weakness; keeping CMS customization outside our main engineering system is the difference that matters.

Today headless delivery is assembled across seams; the target makes seams productized



Drupal core provides JSON:API. The decision is whether to keep owning these seams across 27 instances.

The replacement must satisfy editorial and engineering needs at the same time

01

Platform ownership

GCP, PostgreSQL, GCS, backup, and restore.

02

Global publishing

Country tenancy, languages, roles, and row-level access.

03

Editorial control

Draft, preview, review, approval, schedule, and translation state.

04

Structured experience

Approved blocks and rich text—not arbitrary styling.

05

Digital operations

Forms, SEO, audit, observability, and environment promotion.

06

Transition + platform

Dual-source coexistence, Enterprise AI, optional Vertex, and support.

Failure in tenancy, workflow, forms, migration, or editor usability is a stop condition.

Both platforms clear the infrastructure baseline; the operating model separates them

Decision area	Payload	Directus
Self-host, PostgreSQL, GCS	Strong	Strong
Next.js / TypeScript fit	Native-strength fit	Strong API/SDK fit
Admin extension stack	React	Vue
Multi-country model	Official multi-tenant plugin + code	Row-level policy or project scoping
Workflow	Enterprise workflows + extensible TypeScript	Permissions + Flows + versioning
Headless forms	Official Form Builder	Collections + frontend + Flows
Environment promotion	Code + migrations; reference-data tooling needed	v12.3 Environment Sync
Audit	Enterprise Activity Logs + revisions	Activity Log + revisions
AI editor UX	Enterprise AI suite + MCP / React extension	Native Assistant; Enterprise custom LLM
A/B testing + SSO	Enterprise static variants + SAML / OAuth 2.0	Enterprise SSO; custom A/B integration pattern
Commercial model	MIT self-hosted core; Enterprise custom quote	MSCL; Enterprise custom quote

Directus is a configurable data platform around SQL. Payload is a TypeScript application framework that includes a CMS.

WEIGHTED ASSESSMENT

Payload leads narrowly because our highest-weight requirements favor code-first React

Recommended

4.76

Payload / 5



Competing candidate

4.52

Directus / 5



Criterion	Weight	Payload	Directus
GCP ownership + architecture	15%	5.0	5.0
TypeScript / React fit	15%	5.0	4.1
Editorial workflow + preview	14%	4.7	4.7
Tenancy + localization	12%	4.6	4.4
Headless forms	10%	4.8	3.8
Environment promotion	9%	4.3	5.0
Migration + coexistence	8%	4.7	4.6
Governance + audit	7%	4.8	4.8

Directus is the stronger packaged product in several important areas

Environment Sync

Pull, diff, and push schema, settings, roles, policies, permissions, Flows, and dashboards as JSON.

Editorial automation

Content versions, policy-driven stages, and visual Flows are strong packaged building blocks.

Audit

Built-in Activity Log plus item revisions and reversion.

AI

Native Assistant today; Enterprise advertises custom LLM and AI translation options.

Why it could win

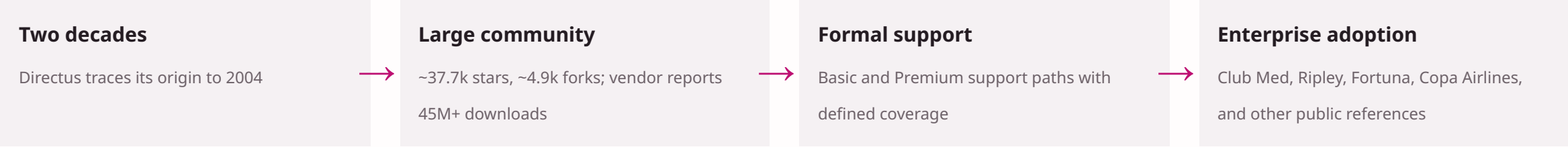
It reduces custom work in areas content teams will notice immediately.

Fit trade-offs

Vue for Studio extensions and no equivalent first-party headless Form Builder.

Payload must beat these packaged strengths in the PoC—not dismiss them.

Directus has mature enterprise support and a large, proven ecosystem



Community channels

Forum, Discord live chat, GitHub Issues, and a public roadmap.

Commercial reality

Source-available under MSCL—not MIT. Assume Enterprise due diligence for our scale and requirements.

Its trade-offs are stack fit, forms, and licensing—not maturity or lack of support.

Payload fits how our team already builds and governs software

Next.js + React + TypeScript

Shared UI · validation · observability · tests

Payload Admin + APIs + jobs

PostgreSQL

GCS on GCP

Govern through Git

Workflow, access policy, migrations, and Admin UI changes are reviewable and testable.

Extend the AI experience

Use Enterprise AI where it fits; add Vertex controls and observability through React only where needed.

Use one engineering model

Avoid replacing PHP modules with a different low-code customization silo.

Payload does not eliminate engineering; it makes CMS engineering look like our normal application engineering.

Payload combines open-source control with enterprise backing and visible adoption



Visible enterprise adoption

Microsoft, Mazda, ASICS, Blue Origin, Sonos, and others. Mazda reports 85% lower annual cost and 3–5× faster delivery for its workload.

Roadmap + contract boundary

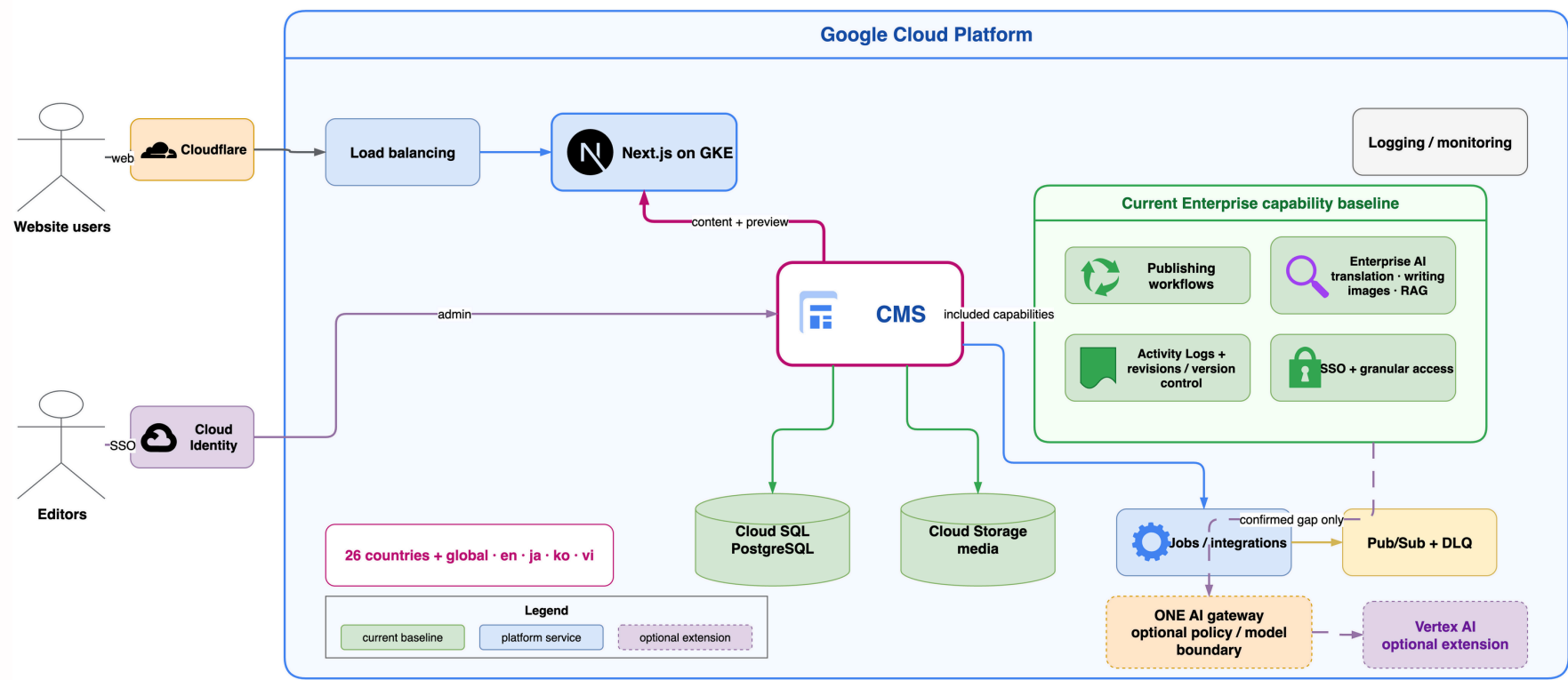
Visual Editor is marked Coming Soon. Confirm SLA, chat channel, upgrade support, feature licensing, and MIT/self-host guarantees.

Open source reduces exit risk; Enterprise support reduces operating risk. Evaluate both.

One logical CMS adds current Enterprise capabilities without duplicating the runtime

Target: one governed CMS with Enterprise capabilities on GCP

Enterprise workflow, AI, and audit are current baselines; a ONE Vertex path is optional for confirmed gaps.



Country tenancy and language localization remain separate controls.

Country tenancy and language localization are separate dimensions

Content scope	English	Japanese	Korean	Vietnamese
Global	✓	✓	✓	✓
Japan	✓	✓	—	—
Korea	✓	—	✓	—
Vietnam	✓	—	—	✓

Country ownership

A record is global or owned by a country/site; editors see permitted scopes.

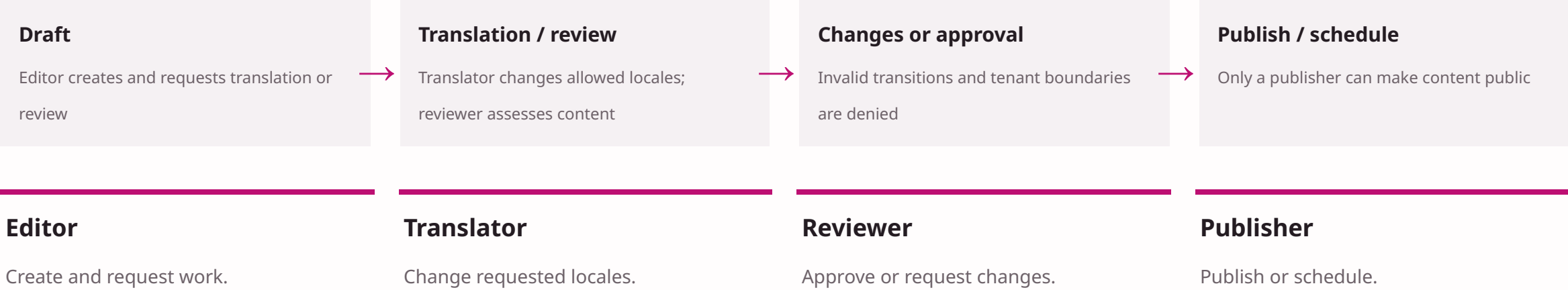
Locale independence

Localized fields and per-locale workflow state are independent of ownership.

No default duplication

Separate databases are reserved for a documented legal or security exception.

Workflow policy becomes testable application behavior



Start with Enterprise Publishing Workflows; configure ONE roles and stages; extend only confirmed ONE policy and integration gaps.

Editors get guardrails and real live preview—not arbitrary page design

Editors can choose

- Approved blocks and variants
- Structured headings, links, media, lists, and callouts
- SEO title, description, image, and page settings
- Content and locale—not raw presentation code

Payload editor + approved blocks

Editors cannot choose

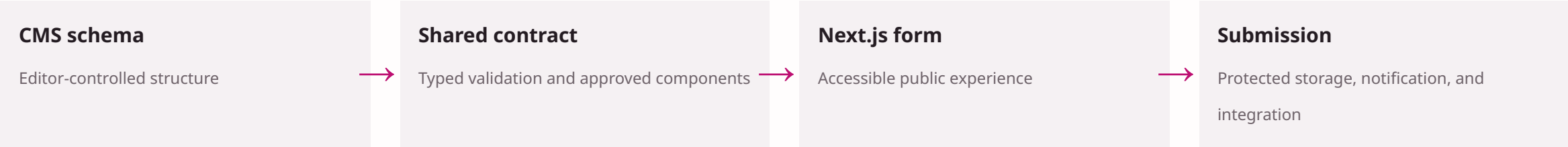
- Raw CSS or JavaScript
- Arbitrary colors, spacing, or typography
- Unreviewed components
- Raw page HTML as the normal authoring model

Actual Next.js page in live preview

Editors own content. Developers own presentation, accessibility, and design-system integrity.

Payload has the clearer path to a governed headless form engine

Requirement	Payload	Directus
Editors define schema	Official Form Builder	Model collections or build extension
Next.js uses our components	Designed for frontend mapping	Custom frontend pattern
Store and manage submissions	Yes	Yes
Notifications + workflow	Emails + custom hooks	Flows are strong
File upload	Supported	Supported through files/API
Conditional / multi-step	Validate in PoC	Custom implementation
Consent, spam, retention, PII	Our production controls	Our production controls



Payload Enterprise gives us AI now; Vertex remains an optional extension path

Directus Enterprise path

Mature native Studio assistant

- Native AI Assistant in Studio
- OpenAI, Anthropic, and Gemini support listed
- Enterprise custom LLM and AI translations
- Validate exact Vertex endpoint and governance fit

Payload Enterprise path

Current packaged tools plus a React extension path

- Writing assistance; advertised translation and image generation
- RAG with configurable chunking and database embeddings
- Official MCP with scoped capabilities
- Extend only missing Vertex controls, prompts, and telemetry

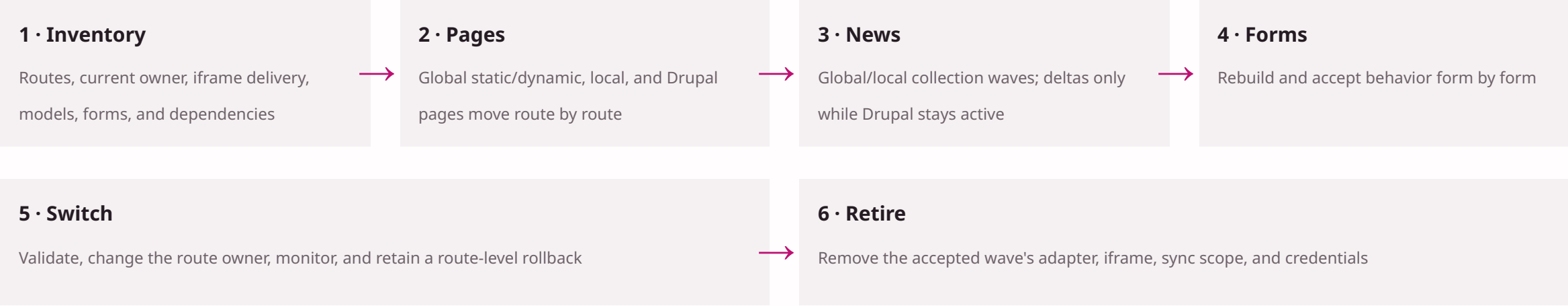
AI may improve drafts. It may not publish, change roles, bypass tenancy, or invent design primitives.

Git promotion, audit, and recovery need different controls

Schema + configuration	Payload: TypeScript + migrations + Git. Directus: v12.3 JSON Environment Sync with pull/diff/push.
Content + reference data	Editorial content stays in production. Countries, taxonomies, templates, and controlled defaults use versioned export/diff/import. PII is sanitized before lower environments.
Audit + recovery	Payload Enterprise: Activity Logs + revisions/version control. Directus: Activity Log + revisions. Validate retention, immutability, export, SIEM, tenant scope, and restore drills.

Directus wins packaged environment promotion. Payload needs explicit reference-data promotion and drift reporting.

Next.js can serve both CMSs while route ownership moves to Payload

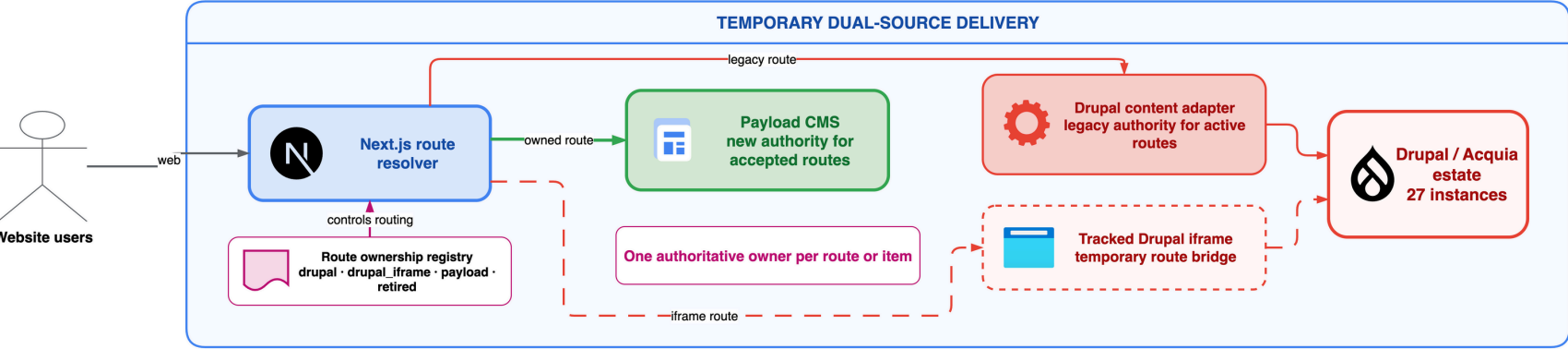


Migrate → validate → switch route ownership → monitor → retire the Drupal connection.

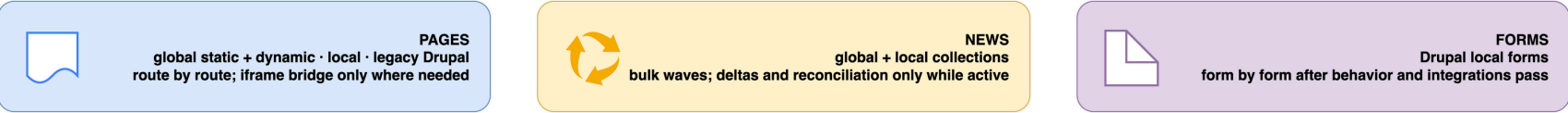
During coexistence, Next.js routes to Payload, Drupal adapters, or tracked iframes

Coexistence: Next.js serves both CMSs while ownership moves in waves

Pages, news, and forms use the lightest safe migration method; each accepted wave retires its Drupal connection.



MIGRATION LANES



EVERY WAVE



Frontend coexistence does not mean dual editing: rollback changes route ownership; it never reverse-syncs content.

Preserve legacy rich text first; normalize it after risk is removed

Drupal source	Initial treatment	Later treatment
Structured Paragraphs	Map to approved CMS blocks	Improve mappings as models evolve
Simple static pages	Migrate individually to structured fields	Editorial refinement
Large rich-text bodies	Restricted <code>legacyBody</code> representation	Normalize selectively after cutover
Global / country posts	Map tenant, locale, taxonomy, and SEO	Consolidate duplicate patterns
Forms	Inventory fields and behavior	Rebuild and acceptance-test before traffic

Sanitize	Rewrite	Govern
Explicit allowlist; no scripts; flag unsupported embeds.	Internal links and media references; preserve source HTML for traceability.	Legacy rendering still uses the Next.js design system.

Preserve fidelity first. Normalize based on value—not during the highest-risk cutover step.

Savings come from retiring duplicated platforms—not from a “free CMS” claim

3-year TCO = vendor + GCP + build/migration + run/support + dual-run – retired Acquia/Varnish/Drupal cost

Cost area	Payload	Directus
Self-hosted core	MIT; \$0 software license	MSCL; Core tier has limits
Enterprise	Custom quote	Custom quote
Public price anchor	No public Enterprise price	Team \$499/month annually; Enterprise custom
Infrastructure	GKE + Cloud SQL + GCS + observability	Broadly similar GCP footprint
Custom engineering	Validate Enterprise before estimating extensions	Validate custom LLM and ONE-specific gaps
Stack + training	Lower React/TypeScript mismatch	Vue for Studio extensions
Exit risk	Low core-license dependency	Portable data; contract usage rights matter

Do not call Payload “free” or use Directus Team pricing as our expected Enterprise cost.

Approve a gated Payload PoC, then make one platform decision

Decision requested: approve a time-boxed Payload team PoC on GCP and parallel Enterprise due diligence.

1. Country and locale isolation under real roles.
2. Content-manager workflow, translation, live preview, trash, and restore.
3. A complex dynamic form with consent, upload, notifications, and retention.
4. GKE + Cloud SQL + GCS, logging, backup, and restore.
5. Dual-source Next.js routing, tracked iframe routes, lane-based migration, and per-wave connection retirement.
6. Upgrade safety for custom Admin and workflow code.
7. Payload Enterprise AI demonstrated against ONE roles, locales, audit, and governance; optional Vertex only for confirmed gaps.
8. Enterprise support, SLA, security, chat channel, and commercial terms.

Critical gates pass → implementation plan + quantified TCO

Fundamental gate fails → reopen selection using the Directus evidence

Replace 27 CMS stacks with one governed content platform—not one difficult ecosystem with another.

Scoring method and sensitivity

Score	Meaning
5.0	Strong official capability or unusually natural fit; low residual risk
4.0	Meets the requirement with normal configuration or modest custom work
3.0	Feasible, but meaningful custom work or operational controls remain
2.0	Major gaps or high implementation and maintenance risk
1.0	Does not credibly meet the requirement

What favors Payload

TypeScript/React fit, headless forms, tenancy model, migration extensibility, and MIT exit path.

What favors Directus

Native Studio AI, environment sync, and lower initial integration effort.

The recommendation is sensitive by design. Debate weights explicitly instead of debating brands.

Full capability maturity matrix

Capability	Payload	Directus	PoC focus
GCP / PostgreSQL / GCS	Official + configurable	Native/configurable	Deployment and restore
Tenancy / localization	Official plugin + code	Policy/project model	Isolation tests
Draft / versions / preview	Native	Native/configurable	Editor usability
Workflow / translation	Enterprise + TypeScript	Policies + Flows	Demonstrate + test
Forms	Official plugin	Custom collection pattern	Complex real form
Audit	Enterprise Activity Logs + revisions	Activity Log + revisions	Retention / export / SIEM
Environment promotion	Code + migrations	Environment Sync	Drift and rollback
AI	Enterprise suite + MCP	Native Assistant	Demonstrate; optional Vertex gaps
Enterprise support	Available; custom quote	Formal tiers; custom quote	SLA and escalation

Directus strengths and watch-outs

Strengths

- Two-decade product history
- Large GitHub and community adoption
- Formal Basic and Premium support
- Environment Sync, Activity Log, granular policies
- Content versions, Flows, and native AI
- Database and API neutrality

Watch-outs

- MSCL rather than MIT
- Tier and feature limits
- Enterprise renewal exposure
- Vue Studio extensions
- No equivalent first-party headless Form Builder
- Exact Vertex and tenancy design require validation

Directus is a serious competing candidate and procurement benchmark—not a standby runtime.

Target GCP control plane

Identity and network

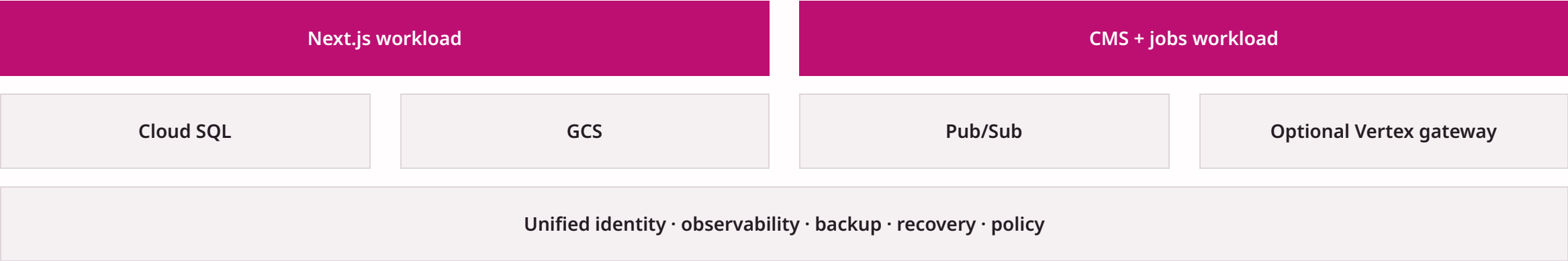
- Workload Identity
- Private Cloud SQL connectivity
- Secrets and least privilege

Data protection

- Cloud SQL HA + PITR
- GCS object protection
- Backups plus restore drills

Operations

- Autoscaling
- Logging and monitoring
- Dead-letter queues and replay



Migration metadata and reconciliation

Control	Purpose
Stable identity	<code>sourceSite + sourceType + sourceUUID</code> prevents duplicates
Revision + timestamp	Orders source changes and supports overlap windows
Mapping version	Makes transformations reproducible and upgradable
Content hash	Detects drift without relying only on timestamps
Route ownership	Records <code>drupal</code> , <code>drupal_iframe</code> , <code>payload</code> , or <code>retired</code>
Delivery mode	Makes adapter, iframe, and Payload routes explicit
Migration ledger	Records attempts, success, target ID, and errors
Reconciliation	Repairs missed events and validates counts and relationships

Use ledger/reconciliation for active collection waves; retire each adapter, iframe, and sync scope after acceptance.

Content-type migration waves

Pages

Global static and dynamic pages, local pages, and legacy Drupal pages move route by route. Existing iframe delivery can remain as a tracked bridge.

News

Global and local news move through repeatable collection waves, with selective deltas and reconciliation until cutover.

Forms

Drupal local forms move form by form after validation, consent, notifications, uploads, and integrations pass.

Every lane repeats: migrate → validate → switch route ownership → monitor → retire the Drupal connection.

TCO worksheet inputs

Current state

- Acquia and support
- Varnish and observability
- 27 environment footprints
- Patch, release, and incident effort

Transition

- Dual-source routing and selective reconciliation
- Dual-run infrastructure
- Content validation and training
- Iframe, form, and integration retirement

Target state

- Enterprise CMS support
- GKE, Cloud SQL, and GCS
- Platform operations
- Upgrade and custom-code ownership

Model both three- and five-year views. Include exit risk, not just year-one implementation cost.

Vendor due diligence and source register

Contract questions

- Exact P1/P2 SLA and 24/7 coverage
- Named private Slack or Teams channel
- Upgrade and architecture assistance
- SSO, audit, and security scope
- Price protections and termination rights
- Self-host and license guarantees

Claims to refresh

- GitHub stars and forks
- Directus pricing and MSCL limits
- Directus AI and custom LLM scope
- Payload Enterprise AI, Activity Logs, revisions, and SLA
- Figma ownership and MIT commitment
- Public customer references

Community channels are useful. Production support, escalation, and commercial protection must be contractual.